8

Online Communities and Internet Linguistic Practices

Many communities these days are formed, maintained, or challenged at least in part on the internet through linguistic interactions that are mediated by computers, cell phones, tablets, or other devices. It is important to situate these newer forms of technology in their broader social, historical, and political contexts – what some scholars have called "sociotechnical systems" (Pfaffenberger 1992; Marx, L. 2010). These technologically mediated communities, which we will be referring to as "online communities," for the sake of simplicity, should be seen as embedded in complex webs of relationships and lived experiences that span across people and objects as well as between "real life" and the cyber world. As such, the language use, values, and priorities of people in these online communities shape, and are shaped by the cultural norms and power dynamics, in the societies in which they take place. Because technology "is no less a product of social relations than other domains of culture" (Dunbar-Hester 2020:12; cf. Oldenziel 2006), people's technologically mediated linguistic interactions are often "intertwined with every other way that they communicate" (Gershon 2010:14). This is true whether people are engaged in casual socializing with friends, professional exchanges at work, or "hashtag activism" protesting systemic racism (Bonilla and Rosa 2015).

At the core of many technologically mediated interactions is literacy. While it is definitely possible to interact online through audio, video, or the exchange of images rather than through reading and writing, written texts often play a central role in many online

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communities, often interwoven with orality in some of the same ways discussed in Chapter 7. And, as we saw in the study of stylistic shifts in instant messaging (IM) between 2003 and 2006 (Jones and Schieffelin 2009), technologically mediated linguistic conventions can change very rapidly. The next section reviews some changes that have already occurred.

Online Literacy Practices

To start with, it is important to understand that language is always changing. It is completely natural that the ways people speak and write have shifted over the years. Because of this, no matter which signed or spoken language you look at, there are usually noticeable differences in linguistic practices between older and younger generations, and even more dramatic differences between twenty-first century language and language from several hundred years ago. Decades of research across many languages indicates that linguistic shifts tend to be initiated by younger people as opposed to older people, and by women more often than men. "Research in other centuries, languages, and regions continues to find that women lead linguistic change, in dozens of specific changes in specific cities and regions," notes Gretchen McCulloch (2019:34).[1] And yet, as we will explore further in Chapter 10, there are plenty of examples of language use online and elsewhere in which other factors, identities, or associations are more foregrounded than gender.

Regardless of who is initiating the changes in online language use, one thing is clear: conventions, especially for written language, are changing rapidly – so rapidly, in fact, that examples cited by scholars (and even some examples cited in this chapter) will often be outdated by the time they show up in print. Perhaps, then, such examples should be viewed by readers as an invitation to look closely at current online language use, gather some data, and conduct their own analyses.

By this point in the book, we can say at least two things about linguistic shifts of all kinds, including those that occur in online language use:

1 Changes in language use are usually accompanied by changes in social practices within a community (and vice versa); and

2 Whenever there are changes in how people talk, there will be opinions about those changes – that is, there will be language ideologies.

The examples presented in the rest of this chapter illustrate these points.

Capitalization, Punctuation, and Emojis

Conventions around the use of capital letters, punctuation, and emojis in online writing have changed rapidly since the early 2000s. All of these practices help to communicate what McCulloch (2019:109ff) calls a "typographical tone of voice" – ways to convey nuances of mood or meaning in online writing. Of course, capitalization and punctuation have communicated such subtleties of meaning for centuries in English writing, but with the increasing use of informal writing through texts, social media platforms, and other online venues, new conventions have developed quickly. Opinions and judgments, both positive and negative, have also emerged as people formed language ideologies about online usages that differed from usages in the offline world.

For example, standard English writing conventions, such as those followed in this textbook, generally involve capitalizing the first word of each sentence and the first letter of proper nouns (such as "Eileen" or "English"). Online writing conventions can differ from this, however. Using all capital letters in an email or social media posting can be interpreted as SHOUTING OR EXTREME EMPHASIS (Barton and Lee 2013:88) – or, alternatively, all caps could be indicative of someone not familiar at all with this convention. The responses to such a mismatch between conventions can range from accusations of rudeness to shrugs regarding the writer's cluelessness.

In contrast to the use of all capital letters, many online writers often use no capital letters at all. As McCulloch (2019:141) notes in *Because Internet*, far from being lazy (which is one of the language ideologies about this practice), people who choose all lowercase letters often have to go to extra lengths to do so because of settings on many phones and other devices that default to capitalization (cf. Scott 2019). Aside from using all capital letters or all lowercase letters, sometimes writers choose to capitalize the first letters of only some words

within a sentence to indicate that they are Very Important or Worthy of Extra Attention, either genuinely or sarcastically. AnD sOmE peOple eVeN usE RAnDOm capITaliZAtION tO rEprEsENT A mOCkIng Or chILdISH tOnE. In all of these cases, capitalization, or the lack thereof, can be used to convey subtle meanings, index specific identities, or reference membership in particular groups.

Conventions around online punctuation use can also differ from standards for formal writing, and just as is the case with capitalization, misunderstandings can arise if people interpret the punctuation usage differently. For example, the use of a period (called a "full stop" in British and Indian English) has come to mean something quite different from the simple indication of the end of a sentence. Beginning in the early 2010s, when used in texting, a period at the end of a phrase or sentence came to indicate annoyance, anger, or even passive aggressiveness. As Ben Crair wrote in 2013 in an article entitled, "The Period is Pissed":

> The period was always the humblest of punctuation marks. Recently, however, it's started getting angry. I've noticed it in my text messages and online chats, where people use the period not simply to conclude a sentence, but to announce "I am not happy about the sentence I just concluded."
>
> Say you find yourself limping to the finish of a wearing workday. You text your girlfriend: "I know we made a reservation for your bday tonight but wouldn't it be more romantic if we ate in instead?" If she replies,
>
> we could do that
>
> Then you can ring up Papa John's and order something special. But if she replies, we could do that.
>
> Then you should probably drink a cup of coffee: You're either going out or you're eating Papa John's alone (Crair 2013).

The use of several periods in a row, called ellipses, can also convey different meanings online compared to offline, and are often interpreted differently by younger and older people. In a blog post, Thomas Moore Devlin wrote the following about ending a sentence with ellipses: "While older generations think this sounds fine,

younger people tend to read ellipses as ominous. I, for example, had a boss who always ended emails with ellipses, and nothing sends shivers down my spine more than seeing an email end with 'We should meet soon…'" (Devlin 2019). Ellipses are not a new usage, however. McCulloch (2019:96–8) found that ellipses used to be common in postcards in years past, and I found that they were frequently used in Nepali love letters written in the 1990s (Ahearn 2001a:125). What does seem to be a relatively recent innovation in punctuation is the "comma ellipsis" – the use of several commas in a row. Devlin (2019) suggests that comma ellipses might be meant to convey a more emotional or comedic tone. Others suggest that comma ellipses (or "triple commas") can be used to indicate drama, annoyance, or emphasis.

Tildes (the ~ symbol) are also sometimes used in online writing. In English, tildes at first seemed to indicate elongation of a word, but then it became more conventional to repeat one or more letters of the word, as, for example, in "sorrrryyy!" More recent uses of tildes in English, however, tend to convey sarcasm, as in this example cited by McCulloch: "Every character on that show has a ~ tragic past ~" (2019:137). Interestingly, in Southeast Asia, people still use tildes to elongate words, thereby conveying cuteness or playfulness. Another example from McCulloch illustrates how this works in Japanese:

> The Japanese word for "yes" is written はい and pronounced "hai." If you want to write the equivalent of "yesss" or "haiii" using tilde lengthening, you'd write "yes ～～," "hai ～～," or "はい ～～." The word-final tilde to indicate lengthening became popular throughout Southeast Asia, in Japanese, Chinese, Korean, and even nearby languages written with Latin script, like Tagalog and Singlish. But since English already had a way of indicating length, the lengthening tilde became associated in English with bilingualism in one of these languages, being a fan of Japanese cultural exports like anime or manga, or even just the secondary association with cute sparkles and ignoring length altogether. (McCulloch 2019:131)

A final type of punctuation that should be mentioned is the hashtag (#). Recalling the 2013 Jimmy Fallon skit discussed in Chapter 2, it is evident that this form of punctuation can convey various messages about the text that accompanies it. Sometimes, the purpose is a rather simple tag of an event, such as a conference or concert while, at other

times, the meanings that are conveyed reference themes, opinions, inside jokes, or other meta-commentaries.

Emojis (e.g.,  , ) allow writers to convey tone more effectively by adding images to their text. They are another kind of meta-commentary that enable online writing to express more of the communicative nuances that are present in face-to-face conversations because of the multimodality inherent in those interactions. Emojis are examples of the gestures known as iconics or emblems, which were discussed in Chapter 2, because they resemble that which they represent. There are also, of course, many other multimodal elements that can supplement the text in online writing, some of which will be discussed below.

It is important to remember that all of these online practices are multifunctional; they can convey many different meanings and accomplish many different outcomes, sometimes simultaneously. They are highly context-dependent and variable, and usages are changing all the time. People can hold strong language ideologies regarding these and other ways of writing online, but many of these opinions or judgments are often not so much about the specific usages but rather about the perceived statuses, identities, or community memberships that they index. In this respect, language ideologies about online writing practices resemble language ideologies about all other linguistic practices.

Online Communities, Relationships, and Social Media

When speaking of online linguistic practices, it can be helpful to revisit the concept of "speech community" from Chapter 6 – if only to acknowledge that it will need to be revised at least somewhat in order to be of use in understanding linguistic practices on the internet. One shift in how "speech community" would need to be reconceptualized in order to be appropriate in analyzing online communities would be to acknowledge that speech is only sometimes involved in online communication. Writing, as noted above, is often central in building relationships and communities online, as are images, audio, and video, including, of course, Zoom and other videoconferencing platforms that greatly increased in popularity when the coronavirus pandemic hit.

In the study of online interactions, it is also useful to apply the concept of "affordances," which Mike Mena defines as "the likelihoods and limitations produced by an environment" (Mena 2019; cf. Hutchby 2001:444). In the case of a social media platform such as Twitter, for example, its affordances include brevity in the form of the 280-character (formerly 140-character) limit on the length of tweets and the ability to retweet, comment on, or like others' tweets. The specific characteristics of the technology are important. In addition, because no technology is neutral, the social, political, economic, and cultural dynamics surrounding the use of a particular type of technology will influence how it is used and interpreted. So social media platforms like Twitter, Facebook, Instagram, and TikTok each lend themselves to different types of linguistic practices because of their unique affordances – in other words, the different ways in which they shape, enable, or constrain interactions on their platforms.

Another concept that is very helpful when analyzing technologically mediated communication is "media ideologies," which refers to the different judgments that people make and opinions that they have about various types of social media and digital communication. Ilana Gershon defines media ideologies as "a set of beliefs about communicative technologies with which users and designers explain perceived media structure and meaning. That is to say, what people think about the media they use will shape the way they use media" (2010:3). The term is very close in meaning to language ideologies, one of the four key terms of this book.

In this age of intensive use of the computer, especially social media, some people's media ideologies express their concern that online linguistic practices might be having a deleterious effect on cognition. In *The Shallows: What the Internet Is Doing to Our Brains*, Nicholas Carr (2011) points to research indicating that reading and browsing practices on the internet have made people more skilled at skimming but much less likely to pause for reflection, and he concludes from this that the internet's effects are deleterious. Other researchers, however, have observed that the introduction of a new technology has almost always been accompanied by widespread public consternation about the effects (actual or imagined) of the technology on language use, attention spans, authenticity of authorship, and social relations more generally. When the typewriter was invented, for example, people worried that typing would make it easier for people

to be anonymous or to pretend to be someone else (Manning and Gershon 2013:127). Gretchen McCulloch cites the landline telephone as another example:

> The phone was as revolutionary for conversation as the internet was: before the phone, you either had conversations that were spoken and in real time with people right next to you, or written and far away and very slow. When the telephone came, all of a sudden you could have real-time conversations with people who were far away, at any time of the day or night. A whole series of norms, established through centuries of gradual normalization of the written word and millennia of face-to-face conversation, were completely upended. This caused a lot of problems that were similar to the "internet problems" we're encountering now. (McCulloch 2019:198)

These so-called "internet problems" include many opinions and judgments about the advantages, disadvantages, social effects, and moral implications of engaging in exchanges over newer communication technologies. Over time, many of these effects will either disappear or come to be taken for granted as the way things always were. The remainder of this chapter explores some of the research on various language ideologies and linguistic practices relating to these new ways for people to engage online.

Who's Zoomin' Who?[2]

It is impossible (for me, anyway) to be writing about language and the internet during the summer of 2020 without addressing the many effects the coronavirus pandemic has had on linguistic and social interactions. As I write this, many, many people around the world have been going through dramatic shifts in how they communicate, learn, and work. Some of these changes will be permanent, while others will be reversed, and of course others, I am sure, are still to come.

The rapid switch to Zoom (or Google Meet, Microsoft Teams, Bluejeans, or any number of other videoconferencing platforms) in early 2020 for classes, work meetings, and social gatherings soon led to a plethora of news articles about "Zoom fatigue." Why, these articles asked, did it seem so exhausting to participate in these sorts of meetings? As anthropologist Susan D. Blum explains, "it is because videoconferencing is nearly a replication of face-to-face interaction but not quite, and it depletes our energy" (Blum 2020). What are



Figure 8.1 The author and her family members participated in regular Zoom calls during the summer of 2020.

these near-misses that our brains recognize and have to try to compensate for? Here are some examples, according to Blum and some of the many other writers who have held forth on this issue (e.g., Sklar 2020, Cauterucci 2020, Drucker 2020, Jiang 2020; Murphy 2020):

- Face-to-face conversation, whether spoken or signed, involves highly calibrated yet mostly subconscious synchronizing of split-second turn-taking. Because of audio lags or video freezes, videoconferencing often disrupts the tracking needed to pull off the amazing-but-ordinary accomplishment of a successful conversation. This is especially true for signers. ASL users have reported changing how they sign so as to compensate for poor lighting and visibility by slowing down the speed of their signing and adjusting their signs to take account of the constricted space of a Zoom window.
- Even when the audio and video are working as they should, it can be very difficult, if not impossible, to meet the gaze of the other participant(s) in the virtual gathering. This can lead to a feeling of disconnection or even insult.
- Most videoconference platforms default to showing you your own image, which can be extremely distracting or even anxiety producing for some people. While some platforms

allow for the turning off of the camera or just of the self-view, others do not.

- Videoconferencing used to be a convenient way to see friends and family who were distant – much better in many ways than the alternatives. During the pandemic, videoconferencing became an often-mandatory way to connect with co-workers, students, faculty, friends, and family that is much less satisfying than the face-to-face alternative.
- The same space – our computer screen – is now a classroom, an office, a bar, or a friend's apartment. "'Most of our social roles happen in different places, but now the context has collapsed,' says [Professor Gianpiero] Petriglieri. 'Imagine if you go to a bar, and in the same bar you talk with your professors, meet your parents or date someone, isn't it weird? That's what we're doing now… We are confined in our own space, in the context of a very anxiety-provoking crisis, and our only space for interaction is a computer window'" (Jiang 2020).
- In searching for sources of "Zoom fatigue," it is important not to overlook all the other possible sources of stress and fatigue – for example, worrying about our health and the health of others, economic and childcare challenges, and social, political, and racial uprisings. It is entirely possible that people are simply tired of being in crisis mode even more than they are tired of Zoom.

For all of the challenges associated with videoconferencing, Zoom and other similar platforms have provided many people around the world with an opportunity to connect, however imperfectly. It remains to be seen how lasting these changes will be. There will be multiple opportunities in the future for researchers to study these shifts in linguistic practice more systematically, as scholars have already been doing for some time now on topics such as online identity formation and relationship building, topics to which we now turn.

Online Avatars

Paul Manning and Ilana Gershon (2013) present an interesting analysis of the various ways that identities and actions are constructed online. Based on Manning's long-term ethnographic research on Ryzom, an online science fiction game situated in a virtual world full of

alien life forms, Manning and Gershon analyze the creation and use of avatars, which are online characters within the game that a player creates and controls. Initially, they write, "the offline player encounters in an online character a nonhuman other that is obdurate and recalcitrant. But eventually, as they come to control it fluidly and skillfully, they come to identify with it, producing a composite hybrid agent known as a 'player character'" (2013:119).

In addition to these player characters, who are usually the main characters, there can also be "alts," short for alternate characters. In contrast to other online games such as Second Life, in which social alts or escape alts provide players with alternate personas or identities to embody virtually (Boellstorff 2008), in Ryzom the alts mainly serve as "a range of silent alt servants serving as an entourage for a main character, subaltern supernumeraries who perform actions of various sorts but never perform an identity other than that of a 'nonperson'" (2013:122). Thus, alts in Ryzom are mostly silent servants of a main player character.

The process of virtually embodying or controlling multiple player characters and alts sheds light on how online interactions can differ from offline interactions. Manning and Gershon draw on two concepts in their analysis: animation and performance. The concept of animation builds on Erving Goffman's participation framework, which we discussed in Chapter 2. Animation specifically relates to Goffman's role of animator – the mere voice box in a conversation. In the Ryzom context, animation refers to the bringing to life of an alt in a way that does not involve the player's full-fledged identification with the alt. An alt is considered to be something to be controlled, not an identity to be assumed or performed. Performance, which we will discuss further in the next chapter, refers in this analysis to the way that a person will perform the identity of a player character. This difference is illustrated in Ryzom players' use of pronouns. They often use "I," for example, to refer to the main player character, as opposed to "he," "she," or "they" to refer to alts, indicating that they consider the main player character as an embodiment of themselves while alts are considered others.

Whereas in Ryzom, a single person can animate multiple online personas, in the other example Manning and Gershon present, multiple people animate a single online persona. This example draws on Gershon's research on how romantic relationships are navigated or terminated using different modalities such as Facebook, texting, or

phone calls (cf. Gershon 2010, 2020). One of Gershon's research participants, a young woman named Nadone, was hanging out with her friends in an Indiana University dorm room when her boyfriend sent her a MySpace message to let her know he wanted to break up with her. Nadone's friends all collaboratively co-authored a response to the boyfriend:

> NADONE: So we got on there, and I am like fine, I will message him. So I start messaging him. And my friends come in and ask what is going on. So I say I am sending him a message, he broke up with me on MySpace. And they say, "oooh, let us help!" So it was like a conjoined big breakup letter that everyone was helping me with. Everyone on my floor was helping me with this breakup letter. It was like, "oh guess what, Nadone is doing a breakup letter. You guys want to help?" You know. It was the most outrageous letter ever cause everybody had their input (Manning and Gershon 2013:125).

As the letter turned into a real-time exchange on Facebook with the now ex-boyfriend, Nadone's friends took turns typing out responses because they felt Nadone wasn't quick or cutting enough in her answers to him. Eventually, the ex-boyfriend found out that the replies had been collaboratively authored by Nadone and her friends, but even then he had no doubt that they represented Nadone's views. In Goffman's terms, there were multiple animators and authors, but only one principal (Nadone). The affordances of the Facebook platform can lead users to assume that there is a single animator/author/principal, but Gershon's research demonstrated that when breaking up, many of the people she studied involved others in the composition of the message and the decision of which modality to use for the breakup (Facebook, texting, phone call, etc.).

The affordances of Instagram are quite different from those of Facebook, and yet some of the same issues surrounding presentations of self can arise through multimodal practices that merge text and images. Scott Ross (2019) describes the implications of some of these in his article, "Being Real on Fake Instagram: Likes, Images, and Media Ideologies of Value." "Each social media platform," he writes, "has a different purpose, audience, style, and animated self" (Ross 2019:371). For the young women in Ross's study, this was true even within a single social media platform, Instagram, because most of them maintained not only an official or real ("rinsta")

account but also a fake ("finsta") account. Paradoxically, the women posted images that they felt illustrated their authentic selves on their finstas ("fake" Instagrams) and more filtered or retouched images on their "real" Instagrams.

Ross reported that the women seemed very aware that social media shapes their identities. The more that they posted to Instagram with *likes* in mind, the more the *likes* shaped their posts. "To become occupied by a social network is to internalize its gaze," Ross quotes Navneet Alang (2016) as saying. One of Ross's research participants described her two Instagram accounts as follows:

> I am pretty specific about what I post on my main Instagram. There's a lot of thought that goes into what I post… I post pictures of me with other people when I think I look good or it's a nice picture in an interesting setting… Ultimately finding the balance between being myself, showing variety in what I post when I can, and gaining likes is what drives my posts…
>
> My finsta is an entirely different story. I post things on finsta of funny things I've experienced or witnessed. It's usually texts between my family members and I, or a selfie of me with a concise but detailed overview of something that's happened to me… I am completely myself on finsta and don't care about likes or anything (Ross 2019:363).

Much as Manning and Gershon (2013) reported in their research on Ryzom and breakups (respectively), Ross notes that his research participants animate multiple Instagram personae in their two accounts. But, at the same time, the research participants' consultations and collaborations with friends meant that multiple people were sometimes animating a single Instagram persona as well.

Ross's research participants had not just one media ideology for Instagram but two, and they were in dialogue with each other. The women used finstas to contest, at least somewhat, the main Instagram media ideology that pressures them to post only likable content in a society and that regularly dictates how women are seen (Ross 2019:361). At the same time, however, their resistance to this media ideology is complex because they continue to post on their main Instagram site even as they use their finstas to express what they consider to be their more authentic selves.

So Close and yet so Far

Farzad Karimzad and Lydia Catedral's study of Uzbek and Iranian migration discourse offers an analysis of some of the benefits and drawbacks of new communication technologies, which enable migrants to be in touch much more often than they used to be prior to widespread access to cell phones and the internet. While keeping in touch with family and friends back home via Facebook or Telegram (the most popular social media platform in Iran) can help some migrants connect more frequently, Karimzad and Catedral found that in many cases, "*being* connected to the homeland may not entail *feeling* connected" (2018:311).

An example of the ambivalent feelings some migrants experience can be seen in the following excerpt from a conversation between Catedral and a 35-year-old Uzbek immigrant to the US named Mohigul. After acknowledging that the new communication technologies allow her to feel closer to her family than before, Mohigul also notes that some of the images and messages she receives from family and friends back in Uzbekistan make her recognize how different her life and values are from theirs:

1 Mohigul: Yea: I mean just off if I'm on Facebook and the news feeds that I get from peo- from my generation of people who are in Uzbekistan raising their kids there, and (.) and then my friends who have moved to US and it's it's a stark difference.
2 Interviewer: hm
3 Mohigul: First of all the ones who have remained in Uzbekistan they had and whose goal was I'm here this is my country I'm staying here they tend to like marry get married much earlier have kids much earlier have many more kids (Karimzad and Catedral 2018:299).

Mohigul goes on to comment in particular on the emphasis that many of her friends back in Uzbekistan place on fancy dresses and other status symbols in contrast to Uzbek friends in the US who are "more simple" because they just go on picnics. While in the days before Facebook and other social media these differences might have nevertheless eventually come to light through letters, phone calls, or visits back to Uzbekistan, these days Facebook facilitates a more immediate and ongoing sense for Mohigul of difference and disconnection from her homeland (Karimzad and Catedral 2018:298).

In the same article, the other co-author, who is from Iran, describes a conversation he had in California with another Iranian about how disconcerting it was for both of them to see their parents using cell phones during videoconference calls they had with family members still back in Iran. In such cases, the authors argue, "new technologies and their use are invoked not only as the means through which information about a changed home is available, but also as a big part of the change itself" (Karimzad and Catedral 2018:304).

Linguistic anthropologists themselves, as well as other scholars, are another group of people who experience similarly complex feelings about the ways in which new communication technologies affect the relationships they have. Increasingly, it is possible for linguistic anthropologists and other scholars to stay in touch with their research participants who are in distant field locations, even after returning home. Indeed, even while in the field, some anthropologists end up friending the participants of their research on Facebook or other platforms, and, as Gabriela Modan (2016) notes, in many cases, this raises both thorny ethical questions and potentially reconfigures the relationships.

Modan is referring not so much to conducting virtual fieldwork entirely in cyberspace, though this practice, too, is increasingly common, especially in light of COVID-19. Rather, her study focuses on issues such as the difficulty of explaining and honoring promises of confidentiality given how notoriously lax social media can be when it comes to privacy. It is very possible that the researcher might discover something, by virtue of being friends with a research subject on Facebook, that the research subject might not otherwise disclose. Is this okay? And of course, the reverse can happen as well; is it all right with researchers if their subjects learn more about their private and professional lives than the researchers might otherwise disclose during fieldwork? Because of these sticky issues, Modan strongly encourages researchers to think carefully about the difference (if any) between "data" and "background information" (2016:104).

When researchers confront the issues relating to social media connections with their research participants, they can develop stronger, more open relationships. And if they do so with an awareness of power differentials and possible unintended consequences, the insights that emerge will definitely benefit the research.

Conclusion

The study of online linguistic practices brings with it some of the same challenges and potential as the study of offline linguistic practices. As more and more of our lives are lived out online, especially during the COVID-19 epidemic, linguistic anthropologists have an important role to play in helping to explain how language changes on the internet, how selfhood is constructed, how communities are formed, and how relationships are strengthened, weakened, or broken online.

Several of the scholars featured in this chapter, such as Manning, Gershon, and Ross, prefer to use Goffman's concept of animation when it comes to multiple online personae rather than a more standard approach involving the performance of identities. In the next chapter, we turn to a deeper exploration of performance and performativity.